up the empire – not the Mongols, not the Tibetans, not the Muslim Hui minority in the western regions and none of the large number of ethnic tribes that inhabited the peripheral spaces of the empire. In time, as we shall see, Han nationalism assumed the legacy of empire, manufacturing a history of affinity and togetherness with non-Han groups, but unable even till today to hide the reality of Han chauvinism.

The Taiping rebellion was anti-Manchu but not nationalist in flavour. Neither was the subsequent Boxer Rebellion, despite its being anti-foreign. Its slogan was ‘Exterminate the foreign and restore the Qing’, which was why the Dowager Empress, despite the danger the rebellion posed to the empire, decide to support it and declared war against the foreign powers. However, the period after the humiliating defeat inflicted by the Eight Nation Alliance in 1901 was different. There was widespread anger at the Qing court’s abject surrender. It had given away Shandong to the Germans, the New Territories adjoining Hong Kong to the British, and Russia made further gains in Manchuria. The French made gains in the Gulf of Tonkin, and Vietnam was no longer a tributary state. The Americans imposed their own open-door policy, insisting on a share of the spoils. We now see a growing sentiment that China’s very existence was under threat and that only a thoroughgoing transformation could save China. A young Chinese scholar, Zou Rong, singled out the Manchus as responsible for the country’s plight. In 1903, he called for throwing off the Manchu yoke and saving the Han race who were the descendants of the ‘Yellow Emperor’. Here is a representative piece from his writings:

> I do not begrudge repeating over and over again that internally we are the slaves of Manchus and suffering from their tyranny, externally we are being harassed by the Powers and we are doubly enslaved. The reason why our sacred Han race, descendants of the Yellow Emperor should support revolutionary independence arises precisely from the question of whether our race will go under and be exterminated. [4]

This theme was taken up by Sun Yat-sen, who also called for revival of Chinese society and overthrow of the Manchus as foreign tyrants. He advanced the Three Great Principles for China’s revival: nationalism, democracy and socialism. For Sun Yat-sen, too, nationalism was directed